A Rare Family of Barn Owls Moves Into Manhattan

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-16 5 min read

New Yorkers have some surprising new neighbors. A family of barn owls has made its home in a water tower on top of a building on West 75th Street, close to Central Park in Manhattan.

According to Andrew Farnsworth, a scientist who studies bird **migration** at the Cornell Lab of **Ornithology**, this is the first time barn owls are known to have **nested** in Manhattan in recorded history. "It was, like, totally shocking," he said.

Word of the owls spread after Elisabeth Williams, a neighbor, told a local news outlet on October 6 that she and her husband had seen several owls at the water tower. "In a place like Manhattan, you normally really have to go out of your way to encounter nature," she said.

David Barrett, a birder who runs the social media account Manhattan Bird Alert, said he has seen at least one adult owl and five young owls, called **fledglings**. People believe there are two adults. He has also seen an adult carrying food back to the tower.

Barn owl sightings in New York City parks are very rare, the city's parks department says. New York is at the northern edge of where barn owls live, and the state's environmental agency says their numbers have dropped over time.

Now crowds gather each night hoping to spot the birds. "They're magical, they're **nocturnal**, they are secretive," said Jessica Wilson of the NYC Bird Alliance.

Before anyone knew about the owls, neighbors heard loud screeching at night starting in September. Farnsworth said that screech is how barn owls talk to one another. One neighbor, Thomas Obersteiner, now lets nature photographers watch from his roof deck. Williams says the experience may turn her family into bird watchers. "I think we're about to become **birders**," she said.

Word Treasure

nested -- Built or used a home where birds lay eggs and raise their young.
migration -- The seasonal journey animals make from one region to another.
ornithology -- The scientific study of birds.
fledglings -- Young birds that have recently grown the feathers they need to fly.
nocturnal -- Active mainly at night and resting during the day.
birders -- People who watch and identify wild birds as a hobby.

Background you need

Barn owls are pale owls with heart-shaped faces that hunt small animals, mostly at night.

They often nest in quiet, high, sheltered places such as barns, hollow trees or towers.

Many buildings in New York City have wooden water towers on their roofs, which can offer birds a sheltered spot.

Bird watchers and scientists keep records of sightings, which is how experts know whether a species has nested somewhere before.

Break it down

LEAD: A family of barn owls has nested in a water tower near Central Park in Manhattan
KEY EVENT: First known barn owl nest in Manhattan in recorded history
+- WHO: Scientist Andrew Farnsworth, neighbor Elisabeth Williams, birder David Barrett
+- WHERE: A building on West 75th Street
+- WHEN: Word spread after October 6
EVIDENCE: Sightings of at least one adult and five fledglings; nightly screeching since September
CONTEXT: Barn owls are rare in city parks, and their numbers in the state have dropped
OPEN QUESTION: Will more barn owls make homes in the city?

Why it matters

Wild animals can find homes even in big cities, and their numbers in New York have dropped, so a rare nest gives people a chance to learn about and protect them.

Test what you remember

1. Where did the barn owl family make its home?

- (A) In a water tower on a building
- (B) In a tree in Central Park
- (C) In a subway station
- (D) Under a bridge

2. Which street is the building on?

- (A) West 75th Street
- (B) Fifth Avenue
- (C) Broadway
- (D) Wall Street

3. What did Andrew Farnsworth say makes this nest special?

- (A) It is the first known barn owl nest in Manhattan in recorded history
- (B) The owls were raised in a zoo
- (C) The owls came from California
- (D) It is the biggest owl nest ever found

4. How many young owls has David Barrett seen?

- (A) At least five
- (B) At least two
- (C) Exactly ten
- (D) None

5. Why do barn owls screech, according to Farnsworth?

- (A) To find water
- (B) Because they are hungry
- (C) To scare people
- (D) To communicate with one another

6. What does Thomas Obersteiner let nature photographers do?

- (A) Take an owl home
- (B) Watch from his roof deck
- (C) Climb the water tower
- (D) Feed the owls

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Andrew Farnsworth, Cornell Lab of Ornithology: Called the nest totally shocking and the first known in Manhattan in recorded history.

2. Elisabeth Williams, neighbor: Said nature is usually hard to find in Manhattan and that her family may become birders.

3. Jessica Wilson, NYC Bird Alliance: Described the owls as magical, nocturnal and secretive.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):